



MIT SLOAN SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT
MIT SCHWARZMAN COLLEGE OF COMPUTING



MODULE 2 UNIT 3
Media Set Video 1 Part 3 Transcript

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The archetype who builds agents

PAUL MCDONAGH-SMITH: Building agentic workflows isn't a job description that all organizations have today. From your customer base, who tends, in your experience, to be actually good at this? What is an archetype that succeeds?

For senior leaders building their playbook, how do they spot or build that person or that capability inside their own organization? And when the role isn't filled, what's the first thing that perhaps goes wrong in your experience?

DMITRI TCHEREVIK: Yeah. So, in my experience, I think subject matter experts who are also enthusiastic about AI and technology in general are the best people. So, they're typically not very technical. So, they're somewhat technical, but not extremely technical. But they know their space extremely well.

So, this can be lawyers. This can be salespeople, marketing people who have read about AI, they have experimented with the chatbot, and now they want to take it to the next level. They want to apply it in their job. And so, they are probably the best because now they have experience with AI and they can encode their workflows using AI.

So, I actually found that presales people are excellent because presales people, so if you have those in your organization, they're usually technical enough to be able to put together wonderful demos. And the same qualities also work when you're putting together an agentic workflow.

The pilot-to-production graveyard

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Dmitri, as our participants move from this module into how to scale agentic AI across their enterprises and organizations, what do you most want them to understand about what changes between a successful prototype and a deployed workflow at scale? Where in your experience do agentic initiatives most often die in that transition? And what is the one investment that looking back across your customer base was always worth making earlier than companies thought to make it?

TCHEREVIK: Yeah. So, I would like to begin with the end of this question. I think one investment that you would like to make early is actually invest in discovery of use cases. Because very often I find that somebody falls in love with the use case, they want to implement it, they invest resources, they build it very deeply, they scale it out, and then it does not work. So, this AI use case, it is the same approach. It is the same as with everything else, any other idea. Five percent of use cases deliver 80 percent of feedback.

So, you really want to have AI literacy in your organization, then you may want to have some kind of hackathon ideation, some kind of discovery of use cases to happen before you actually select the ones that you want to scale. And then when you want to scale them, there are two aspects to it. One of them is the infrastructure. Obviously, you want to collect all the data, make this data available to agents so that they're grounded in the right

information. They also want to connect to the right APIs, make sure that everything is secure, that the APIs are scalable. So, the infrastructure part must be addressed. But most companies do that. That is kind of a given.

What most people miss is the people aspect because it is a change for the company and change management is very important. If you don't prepare people who will be using those agents to use them, then they won't. And there may actually be resistance there. So, I would say people part is probably even more important than the infrastructure part.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: I'm actually so pleased that you bring this point up because the connection between, shall we say, the models into your processes, into your people, into your culture, into the change management, you're kind of suggesting is key to actually the effectiveness here.

TCHEREVIK: Oh, it's vitally important. If you don't prepare people for that, for using the agents, or if they perceive agent as a threat or a replacement for what they do, then you will literally get resistance. They will say, "Hey, this is the output. You see this? This is not working here. This is not how I would say it." Therefore, it is not correct. I have seen those cases.

And the way to avoid them is you set the expectations, but then you also ensure that maybe people who will be using the agents are the ones who generated ideas for the agents. Then they own it and then they like it, they use it, and they don't perceive it as a threat.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Oftentimes in organizations, we hold on very tight to particular ideas, whether they come from senior leadership or from lines of business. And one of the things that strikes me with agentic AI, how important it is to be pretty brutal in terms of not just what you're starting, but what you finish.

TCHEREVIK: Oh, it's very, very important. And it is a traditional discovery process. You have a large set of ideas. Somehow, you select a few ideas to prototype.

And then you test the prototypes, make sure that they deliver on the expectations. If not, you just kill them. And yeah. And then you pick the few that will be scaled.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: So, that discipline to be deliberate around the construct of your agentic AI portfolio is going to be key.

TCHEREVIK: Yeah. Portfolio management. That is the right term. You should be managing a portfolio of use cases and don't be afraid to abandon the ones that do not work because there are quite a few that will be very impactful.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: And there are lessons to be learned from the ones that you actually discard as well oftentimes. The patterns that we're looking for aren't simply the patterns of success. But also, you know, the patterns of those things, without wishing to say failure, the things that perhaps went not quite the way that you had expected.

TCHEREVIK: That's how you grow. That's the maturity of the organization.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Okay. Well, thank you. Very fascinating, very useful, very practical, pragmatic and a big thank you.

TCHEREVIK: Wonderful. I hope it was helpful.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Most definitely. Thank you.

SPEAKER: Did you understand all the concepts covered in this video? If you'd like to review any of the content, please click on the chapter menu.